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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1949, 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1950-1957

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Section Title(S): The Homestead

Men sometimes settle with maternal kinsmen, but the residential tie between mother's brother and sister's son is weak. Many Middle River men argue that it is foolish to share a homestead with a sister's son. Here a man has a free joking relationship with his mother's brother's wife, or with his sister's son's wife, and he is often suspect of being her lover. Between a man and his brother's wife on the other hand there is a formal respect relationship. On one occasion when a group of Middle River men were commenting on a recent scandal, one said, 'It is foolish to live with a sister's son. You always have trouble. A sister's son has no respect for your wives and you are likely to spend your time quarrelling. A brother respects your wife and you respect his. So you have no quarrel between you. It is better to live with your wife's brother than with your sister's son, for your wife's brother must respect all your wives.' Nevertheless, when fathers become indignant with delinquent sons, they will tell them to move to their mother's brothers as though this was their rightful place. The fact that so few sons act on this advice is probably an indication that they are uncertain of their welcome. MPWE and Upper River men must show great reserve and formal respect to the wives of both mother's brother and sister's son. This does not mean that they are any more likely to live together with them in one homestead although a number of MPWE men said they had come to the neighbourhood to be near a mother's brother.

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Usually there is no particular reason why a man should go to live with his mother's brother or why he should leave his father's homestead when he becomes adult. Since most marriages take place within a neighbourhood, the children of the marriage can exploit their claims to lineage land from the paternal homestead. Only the children of an interneighbourhood marriage may see an advantage in moving back to their mother's home. Inter-neighbourhood marriages are more common in small Upland communities such as MPWE than in the densely populated Riverine neighbourhoods. This

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presumably explains why MPWE men are more likely to move to the villages from whence their mothers came. Then as unmarried boys or in the first years of marriage when a couple must be attached to another household, they live **101** in the homestead of a mother's brother. As soon as they can establish independence, they usually build apart.

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